a department for domestic affairs and another for external affairs. Until independence in 1947, the external affairs department was controlled directly by the Governor General of India. Indians fighting for independence from the British did not look favourably upon civil servants advancing the cause of the empire.

At Independence, there were differing views in the Congress party about whether or not independent India should retain the British civil services. Nehru supported abolition of the permanent civil service inherited from the Raj and wanted to replace it with a cadre of political appointees. In his view, this would be a more democratic system and, in addition to removing the vestiges of colonialism, would create a more patriotic governing class. Ironically, it was Patel who argued in favour of retaining the permanent bureaucracy created so carefully over almost two centuries by the British. In a letter to Nehru dated 27 April 1948, Patel asserted that 'an efficient and disciplined and contented service, assured of its prospects as a result of diligent and honest work, is a sine qua non of sound administration under a democratic regime even more than under an authoritarian rule'. [32] According to Patel, the bureaucracy 'must be above party' and a system should be laid out that minimizes 'political considerations either in its recruitment or in its discipline and control'.[33]

Patel's view prevailed and India's founding fathers were able to rise above the resentment resulting from mistreatment by the bureaucracy during colonial rule. India retained the broad British civil service system though, over time, numerous changes were introduced. Today the Indian civil services are divided into three broad categories: the Central Services (which include forty-three services including the Indian Foreign Service), All India Services (three services, including the Indian Administrative Service) and the various state services. Upon becoming prime minister, Nehru appointed Girija Shankar Bajpai, an ICS officer and India's Agent General to the US, as the head of the external affairs ministry with the rank